Should You Really Just “Build The Thing”

(yes, maybe)

Yerren van Sint Annaland

Founder
Produce Intelligence LTD
yerren@produceintelligence.co.nz

AI Software Engineer
Stratos Technology Partners
y.annaland@stp.co.nz

But first…

How do you find a thing to build?

- Get involved (with anything) and find pain points

How do you build the thing?

- One step at a time

How do you get people to use the thing?

- Make a good thing, and build good relationships*

How do you improve the thing?

- Listen hard to feedback. Really hard

Adam Neely



Do you have PERFECT PITCH?! | Q+A #49

47K views · 10 hours ago



What does music mean?

128K views · 2 weeks ago



What is the slowest music humanly possible?

1.1M views · 3 months ago

But first…

How do you find a thing to build?

- Get involved (with anything) and find pain points

How do you build the thing?

- One step at a time

How do you get people to use the thing?

- Make a good thing, and build good relationships*

How do you improve the thing?

- Listen hard to feedback. Really hard

*Relationships >>> everything else

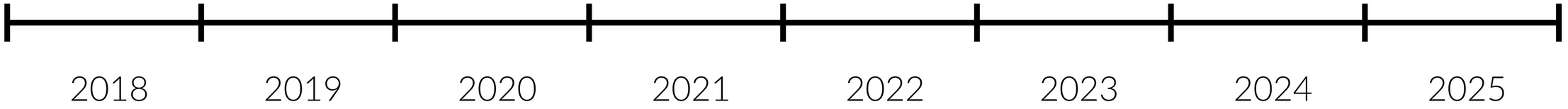
- Be honest
- Be responsive
- Be respectful
- Be friendly
- Actually care – about the clients, about the products, and about doing a good job

Finding Your Thing

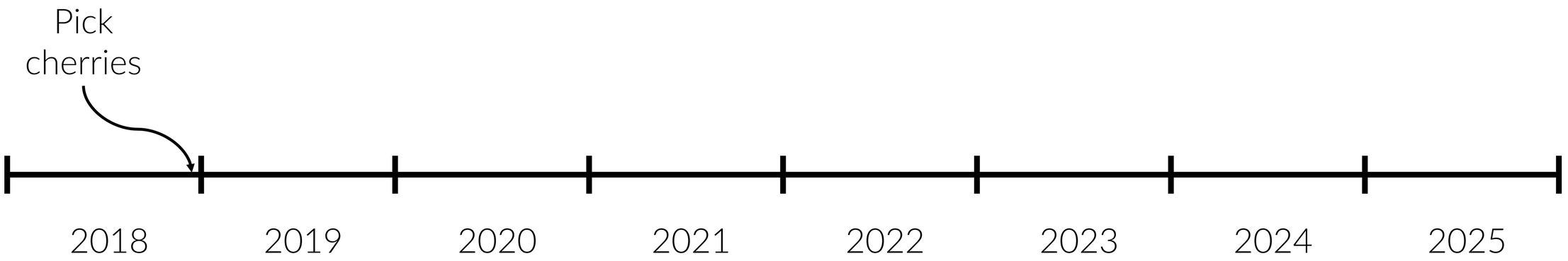
A simple* nine step plan

Why should you listen to me?

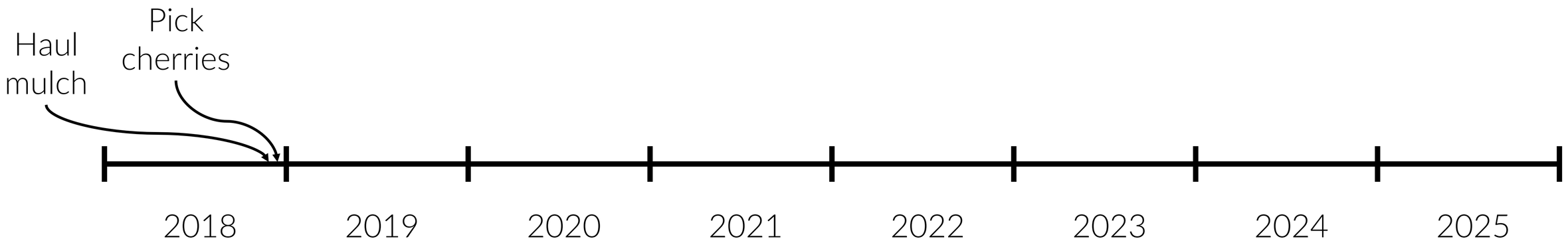
Why should you listen to me?



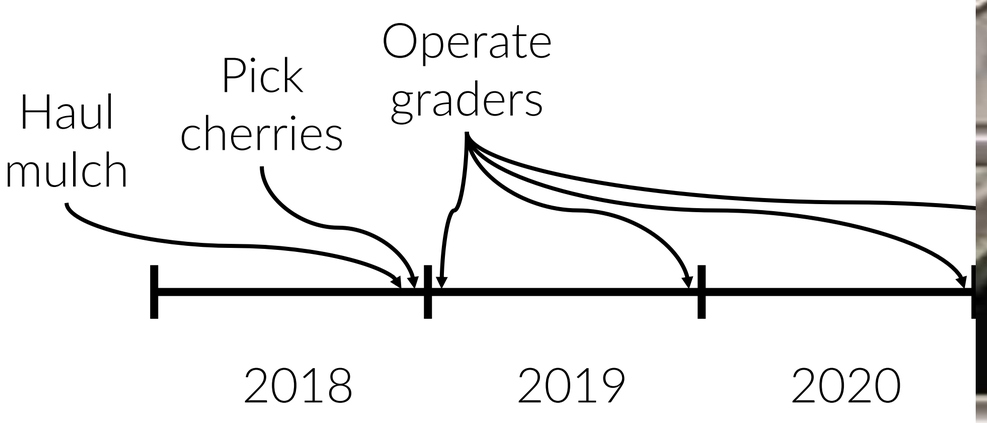
Why should you listen to me?



Why should you listen to me?

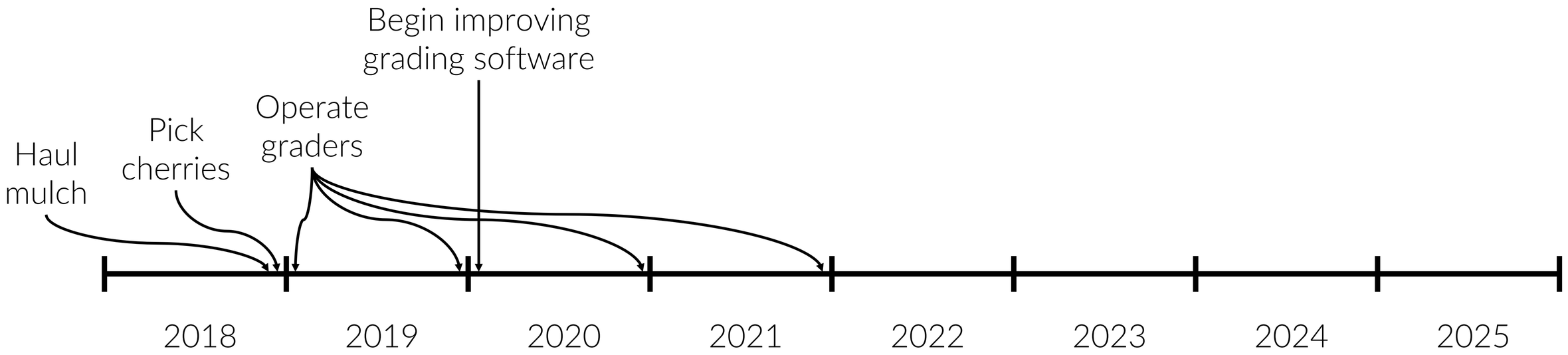


Why should you listen to me?

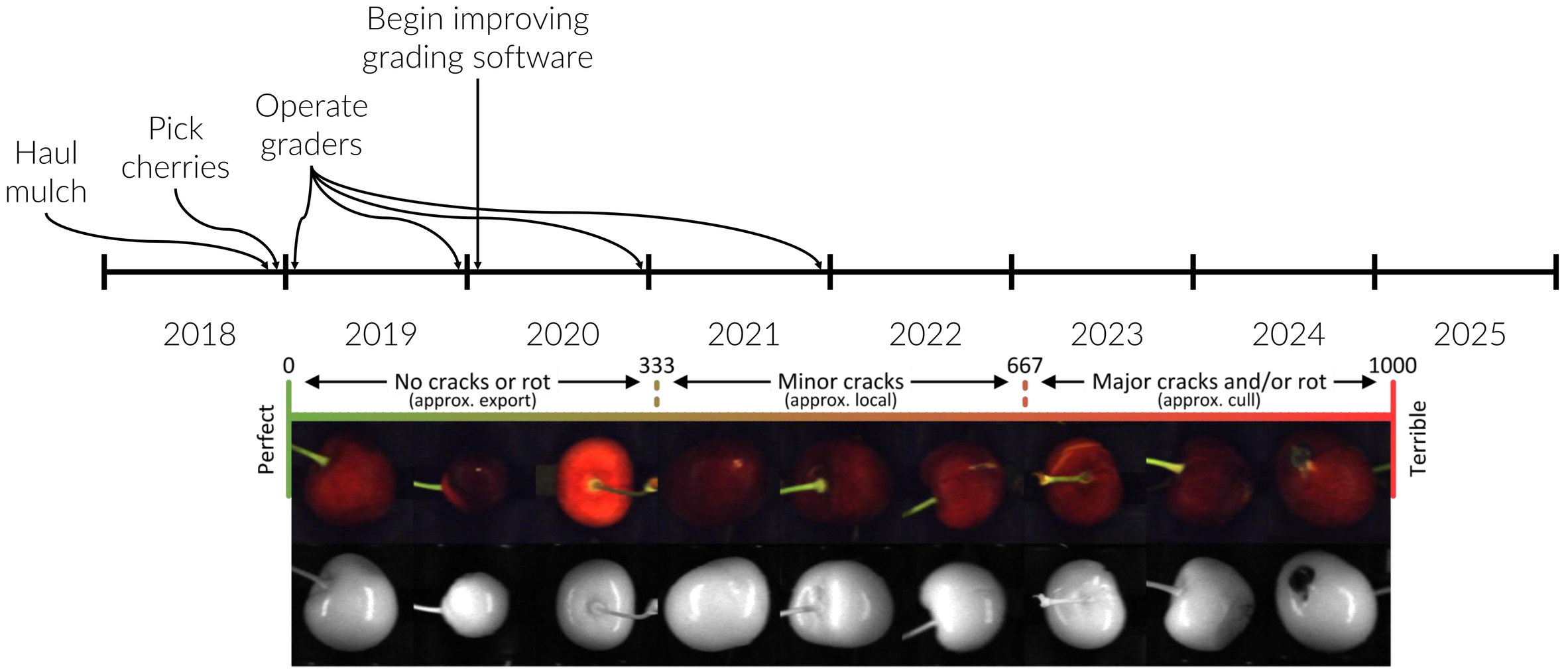




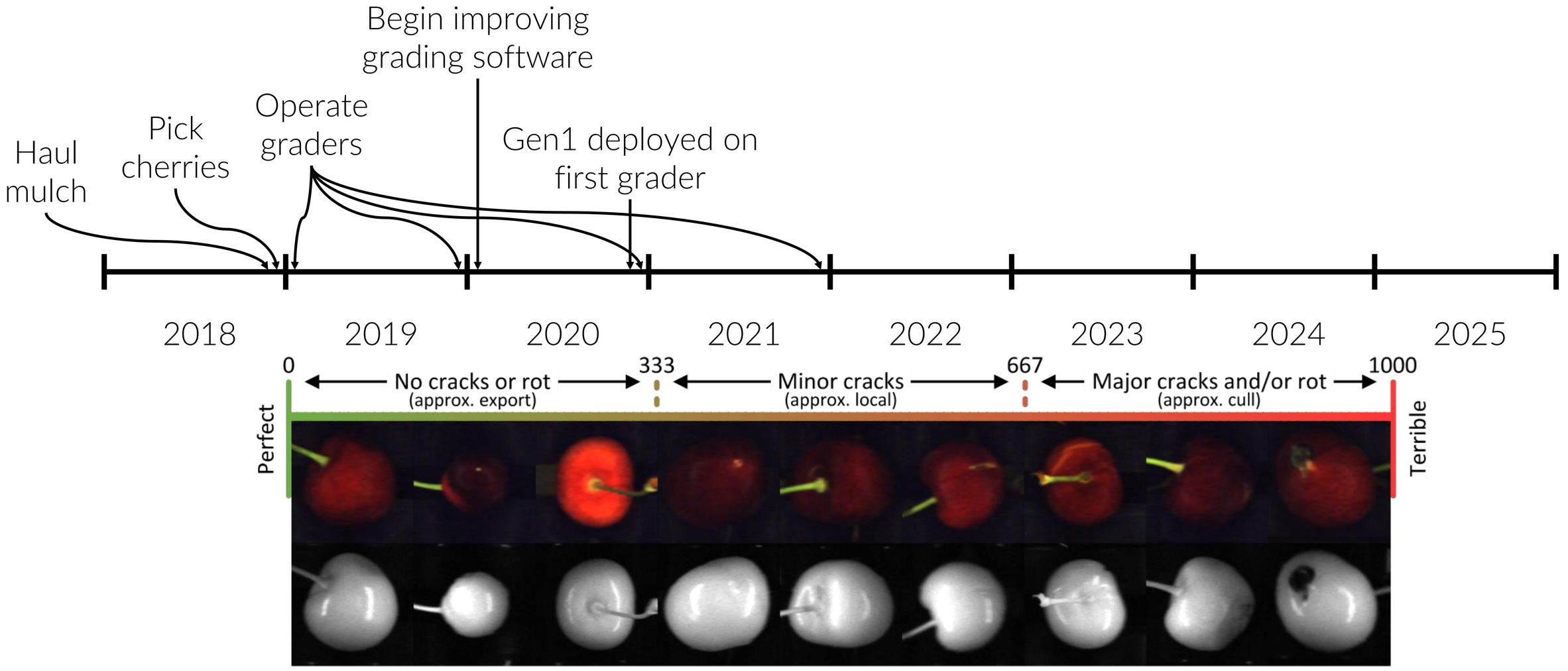
Why should you listen to me?



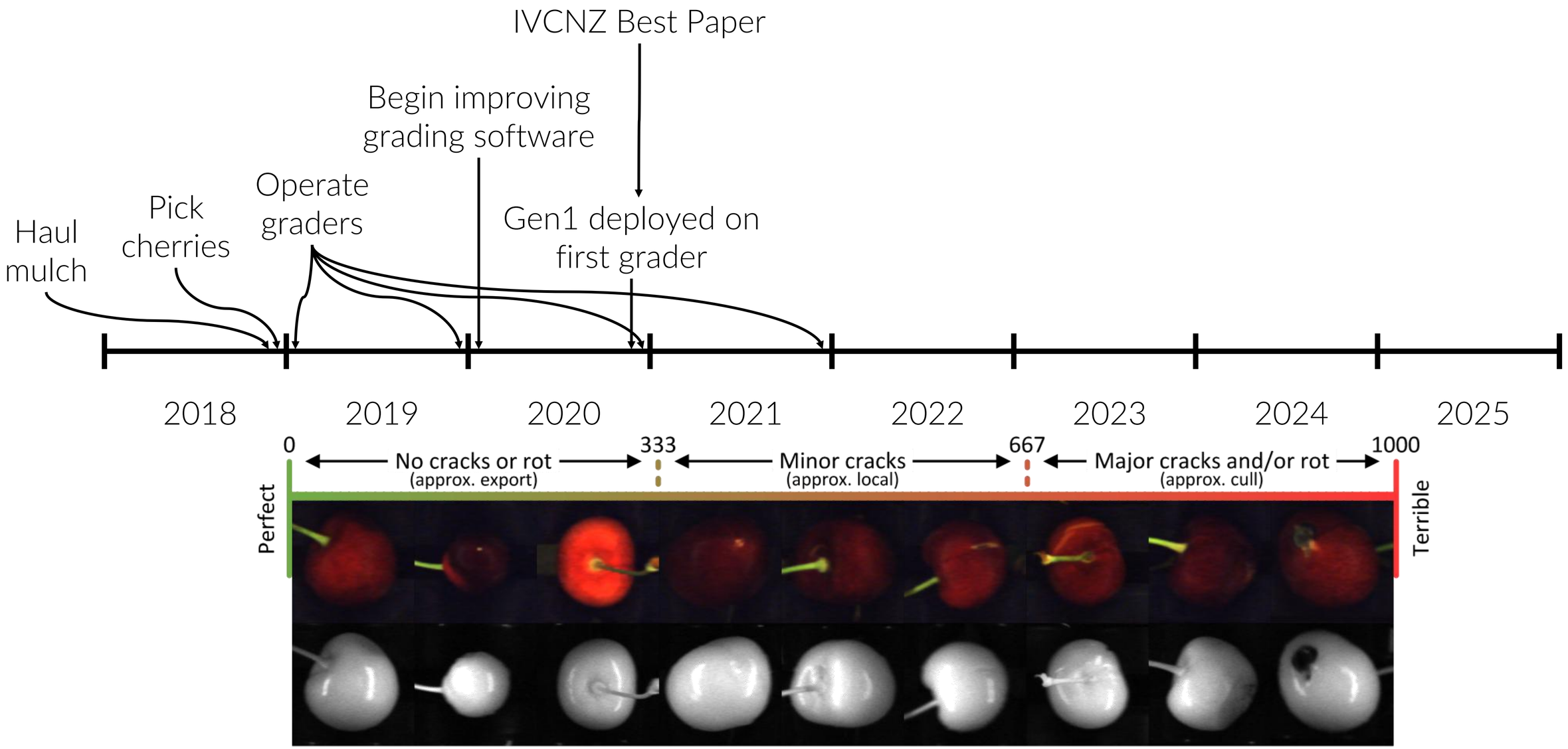
Why should you listen to me?



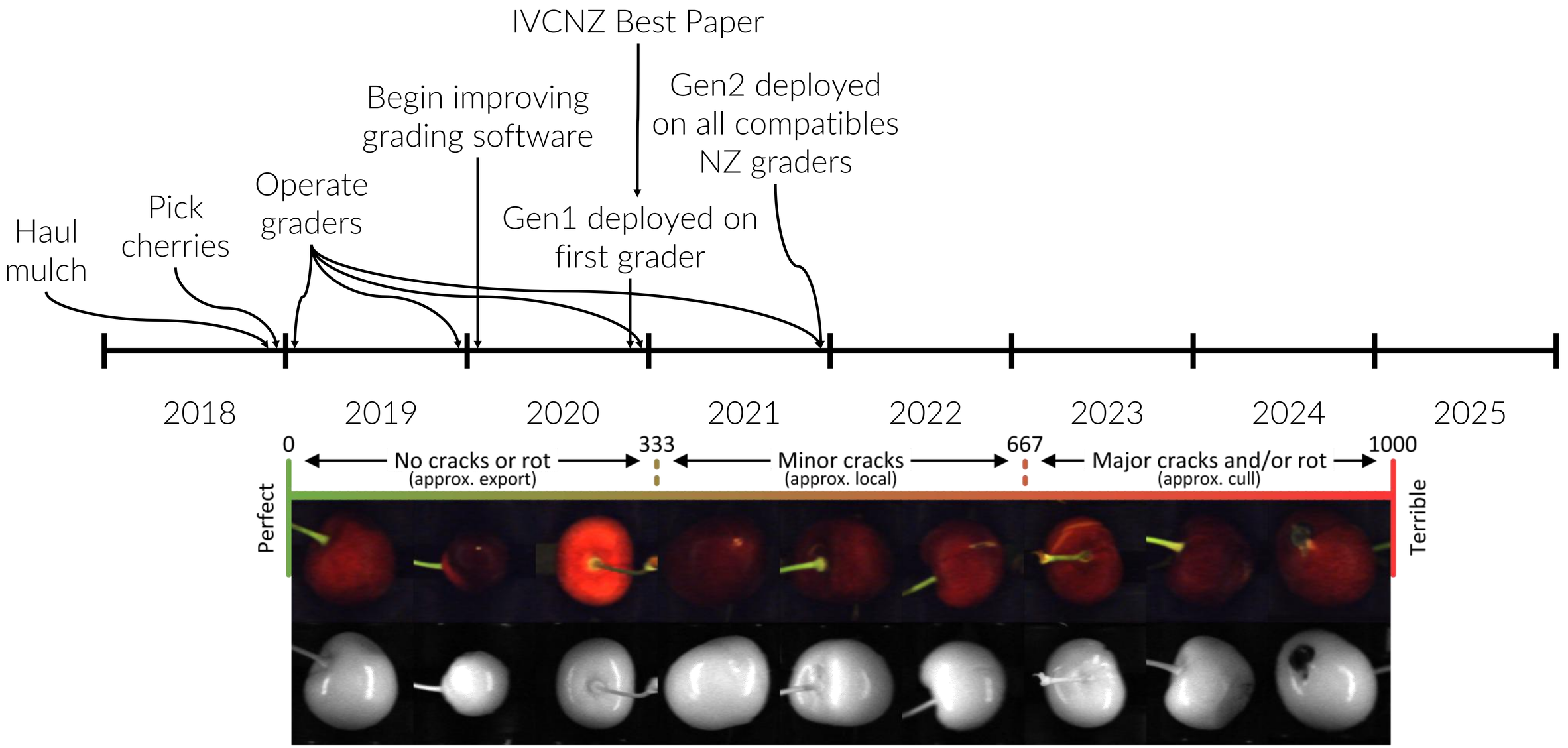
Why should you listen to me?



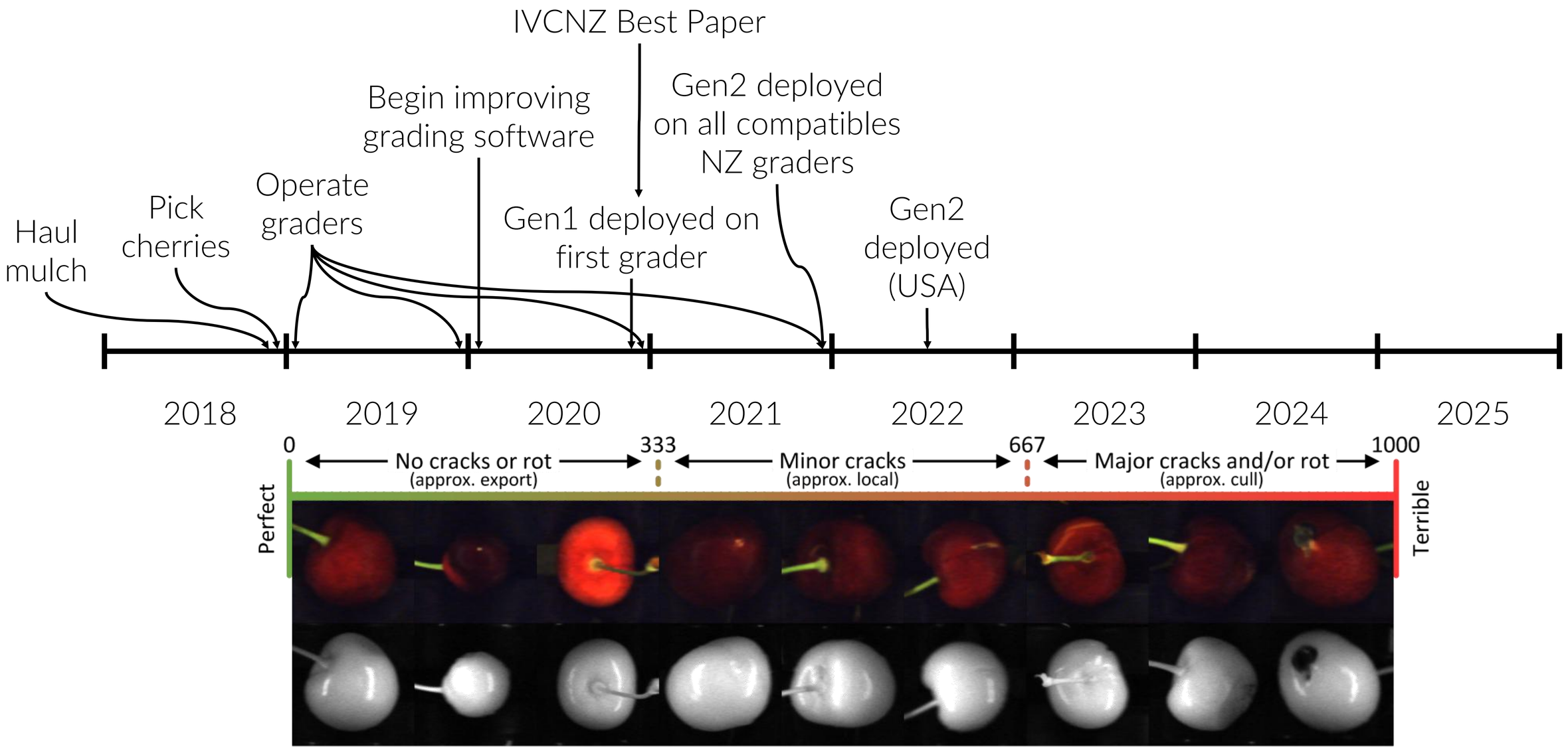
Why should you listen to me?

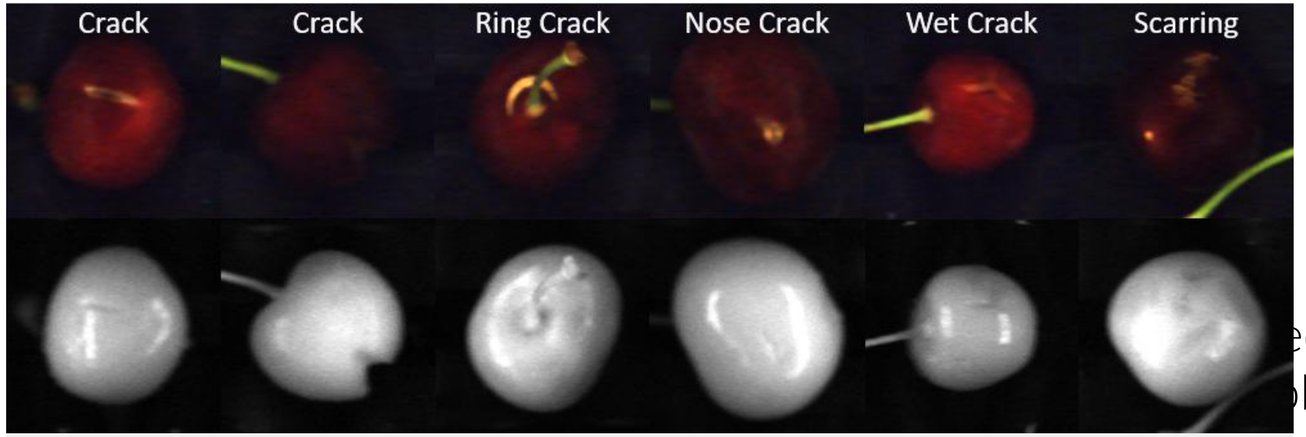


Why should you listen to me?



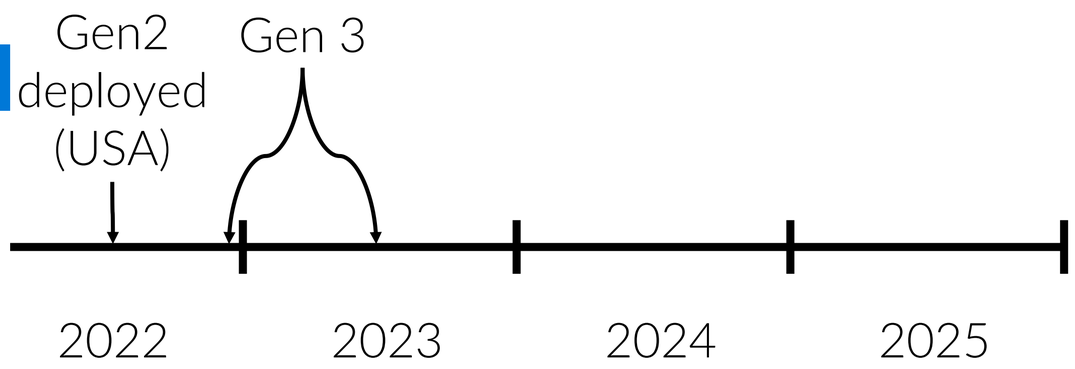
Why should you listen to me?

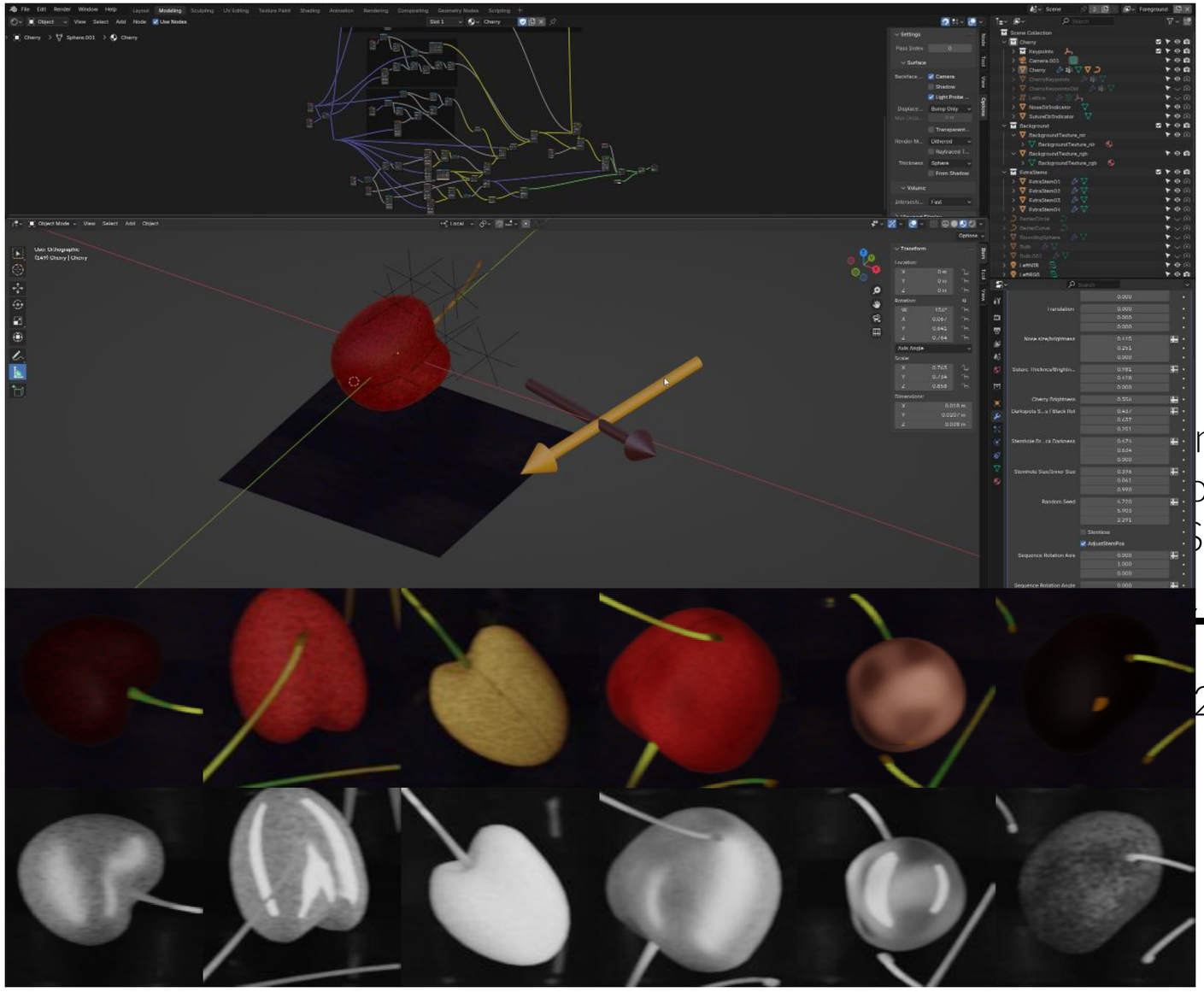




ed
les

```
ring_crack thresh (per stp)      750
ring_crack adj (per stp)           0
side_crack thresh (per stp)      750
side_crack adj (per stp)           0
nose_crack thresh (per stp)      750
nose_crack adj (per stp)           0
suture_crack thresh (per stp)      750
suture_crack adj (per stp)           0
wet_crack thresh (per stp)       750
wet_crack adj (per stp)            0
```





n2
oyed
SA)

Gen 3

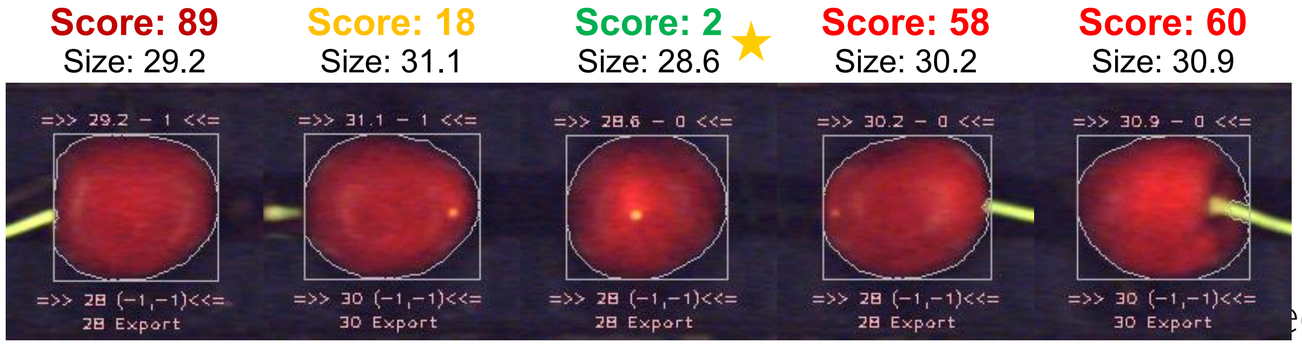
Gen 4

22

2023

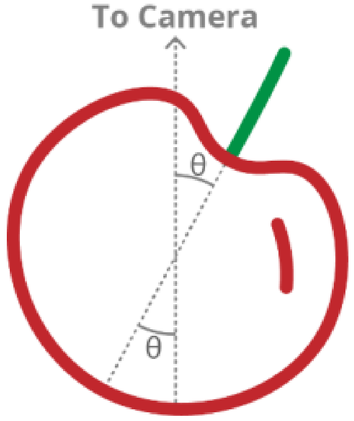
2024

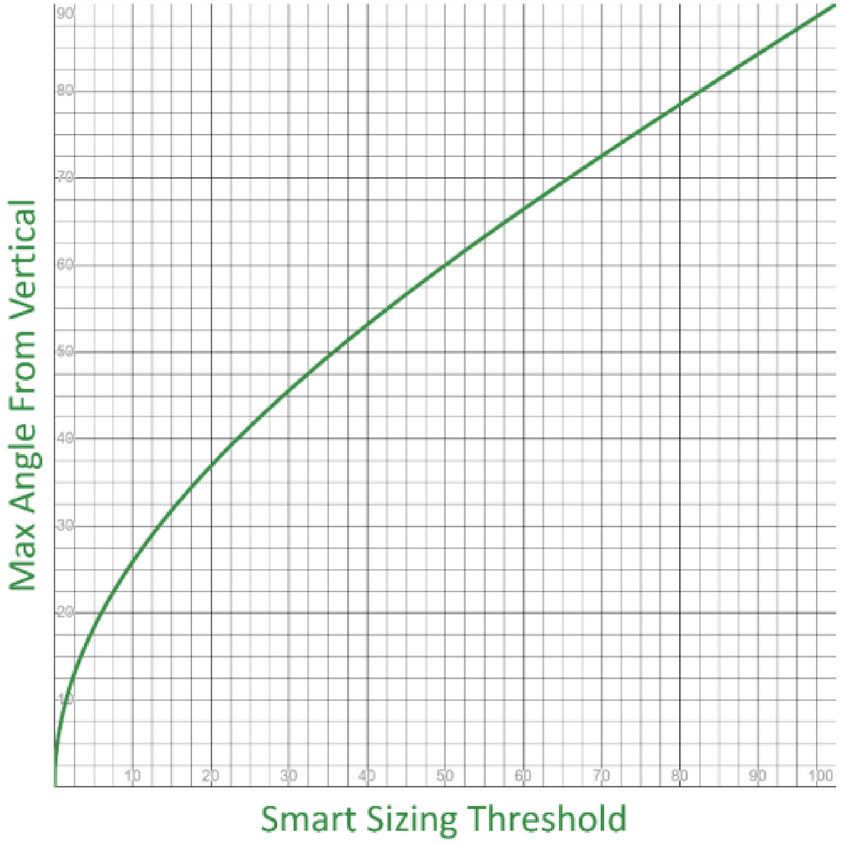
2025

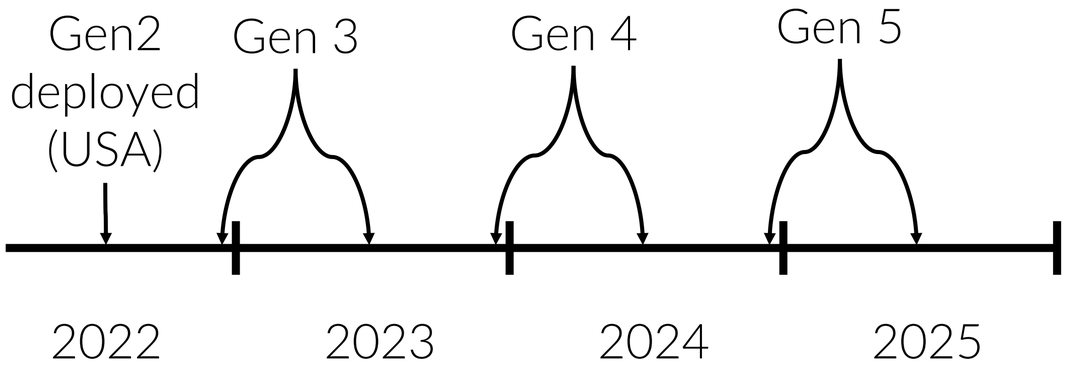

Score: 89
Size: 29.2
Score: 18
Size: 31.1
Score: 2
Size: 28.6
Score: 58
Size: 30.2
Score: 60
Size: 30.9
=>> 29.2 - 1 <<=
=>> 31.1 - 1 <<=
=>> 28.6 - 0 <<=
=>> 30.2 - 0 <<=
=>> 30.9 - 0 <<=
=>> 28 (-1,-1)<<=
28 Export
=>> 30 (-1,-1)<<=
30 Export
=>> 28 (-1,-1)<<=
28 Export
=>> 28 (-1,-1)<<=
28 Export
=>> 30 (-1,-1)<<=
30 Export

ed

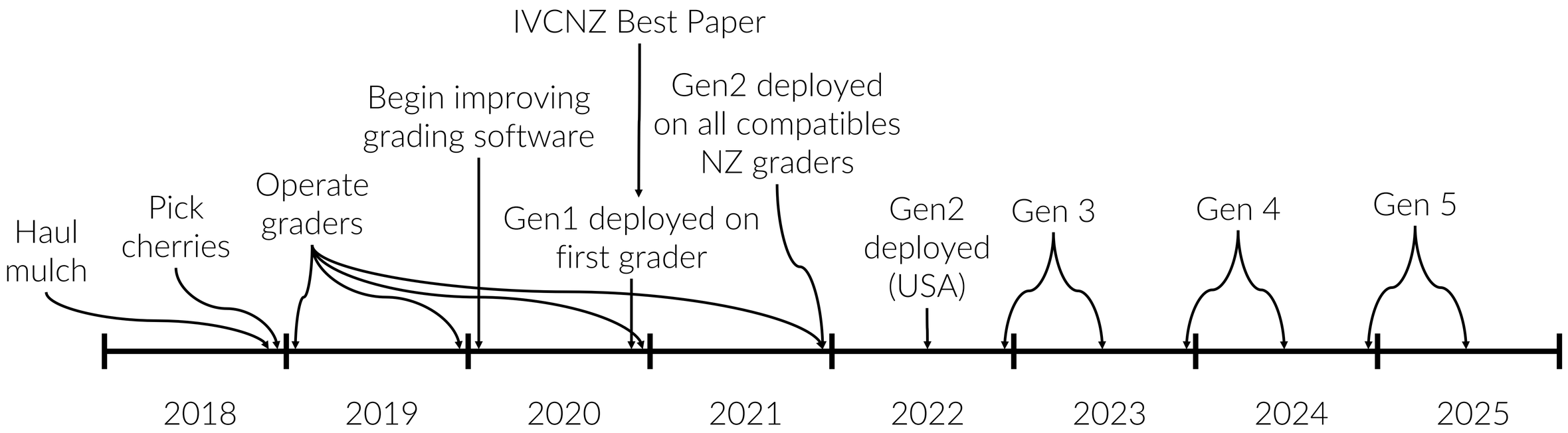
les


To Camera
θ
θ


Max Angle From Vertical
Smart Sizing Threshold
10
20
30
40
50
60
70
80
90
100


Gen2 deployed (USA)
Gen 3
Gen 4
Gen 5
2022
2023
2024
2025

Why should you listen to me?



Cherry grading

Improved Performance

- Massive increase in overall performance (both precision and recall)

User Friendliness

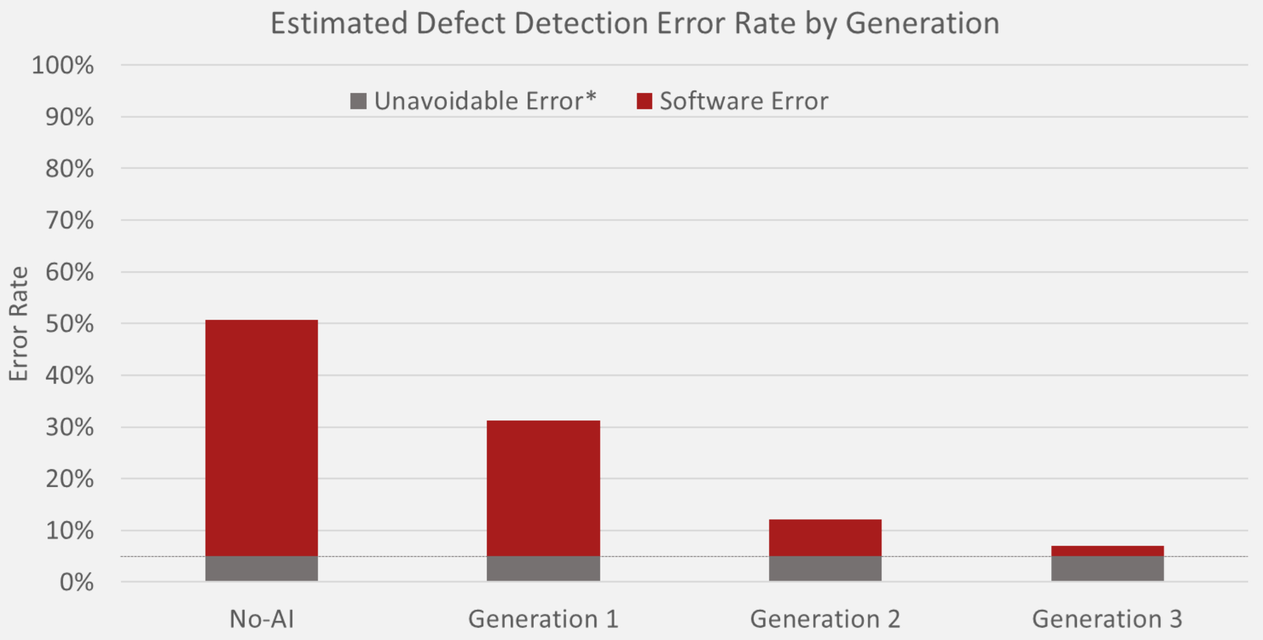
- Overwhelming feedback is that the system is now easier to operate

Cost Savings

- Packhouses have dropped from 2-3 human grading staff per exit to 0-1
- Overall savings estimated at upwards of $200 per tonne of fruit packed.

Reduced Food Waste

- Estimated at upwards of 100,000kgs of reduced food waste



No-AI and *Generation 1* evaluations performed by running cherries through the grader. *Generation 2* and *Generation 3* evaluations estimated by comparing performance to *Generation 1* on a large set of saved images.

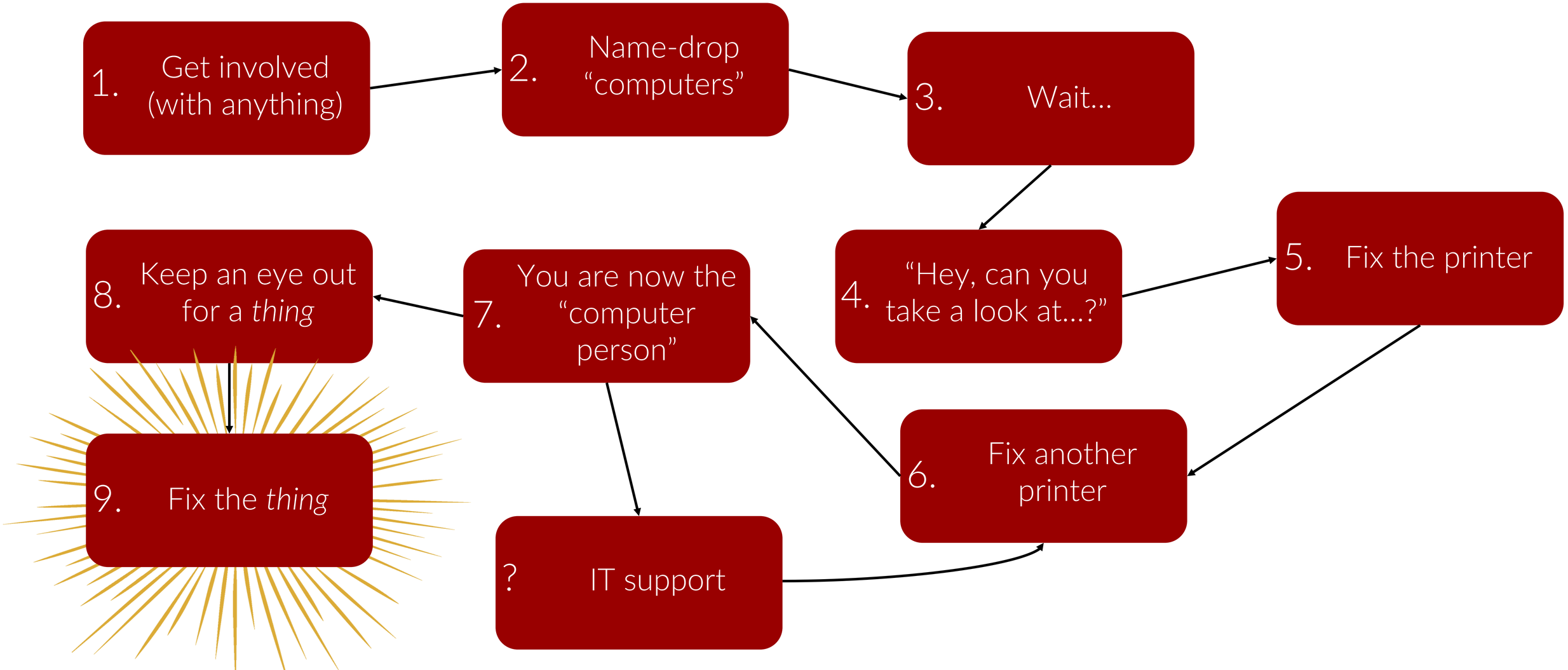
*Errors due to defects not being visible to the camera. Shown at 5% here, but can vary depending on the running conditions.

Finding Your Thing

A simple* nine step plan

How do you find a thing to build?

A simple* nine step plan



Building Your Thing

One step at a time

Building your thing

One step at a time

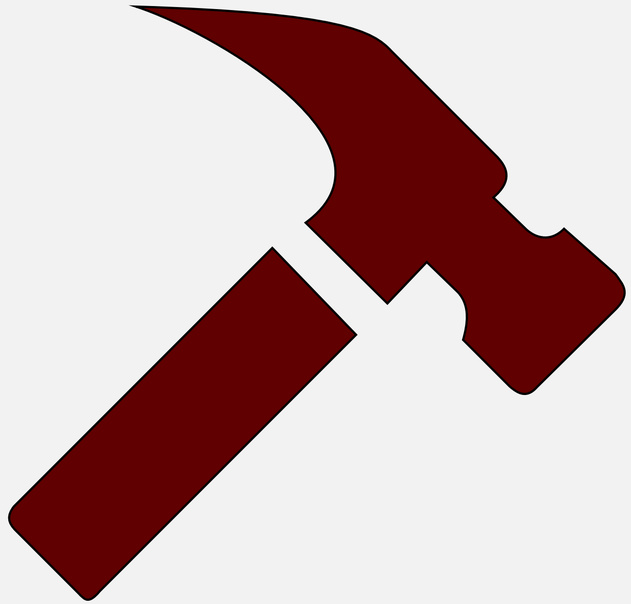
- Avoid analysis paralysis
- Start with the smallest possible thing
- Prove that it's worthwhile
- Iterate iterate iterate

Take (measured) risks

- You probably won't know *exactly* how your thing will work before you start
- You might not even know if it's possible at all

Learn on the job

- You don't need to be an expert to start building
- Focus on the thing, not on the tools
- The best way to learn is by doing



Getting Users for Your Thing

Relationships, relationships, relationships

Getting users for your thing

Make something good

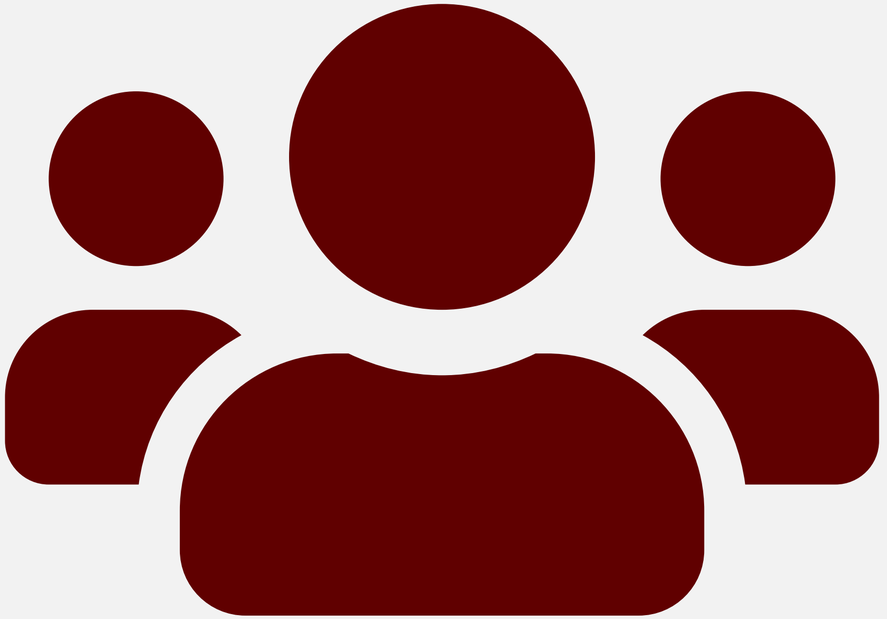
- Your thing makes someone's life easier/better/more efficient

Build good relationships

- Be honest, responsive, respectful, genuine
- Truly care about doing right by people

You just need one person

- A single client/user who is willing to vouch for your thing is one of the most valuable assets you can have



Improving Your Thing

Listen hard

Improving your thing

Listen hard

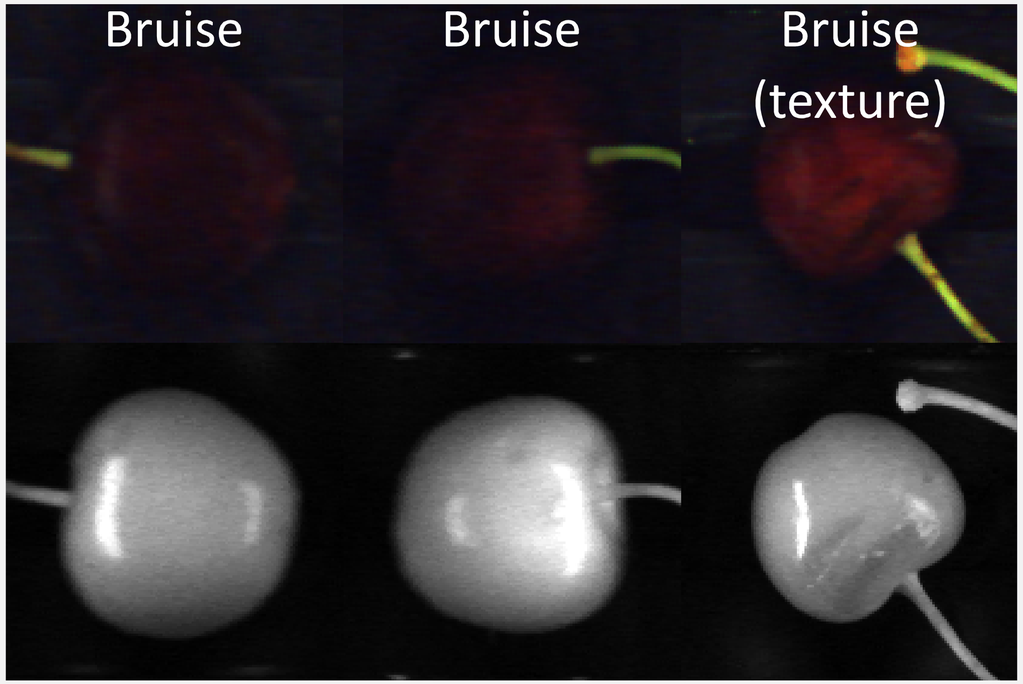
- YOU DO NOT KNOW WHAT THE USER WANTS
- The user also doesn’t know what the user wants

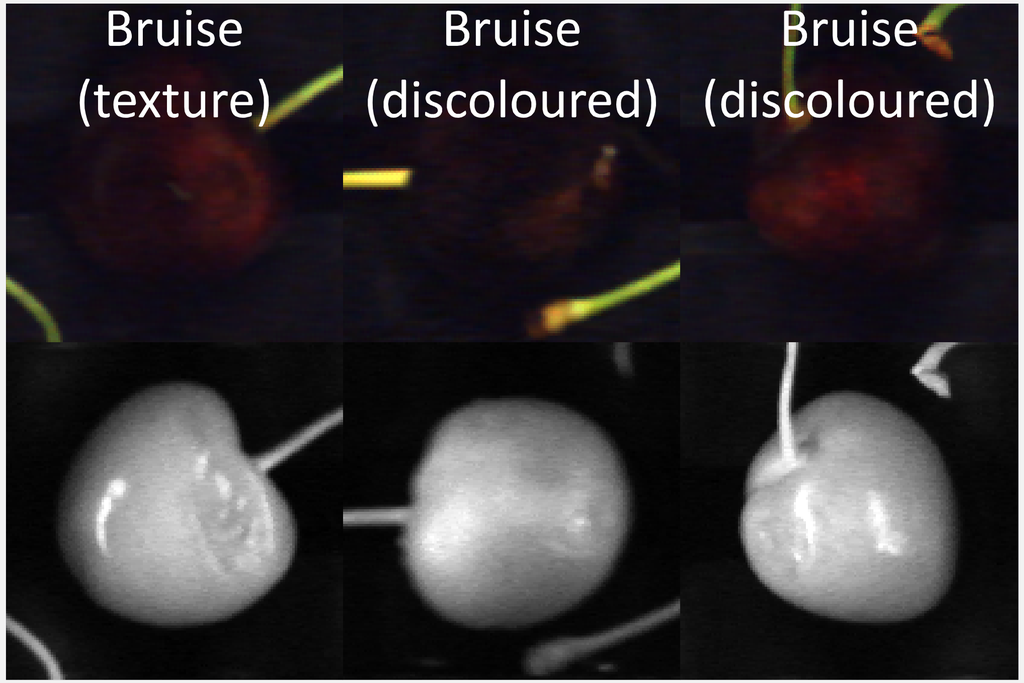
Don’t get attached to specific features

- If the users don’t want/need it
- If it doesn’t deliver the value you expected
- Pivot quickly
- Back yourself

Start from day one

- Gather feedback before you start building
- Gather feedback while you’re building
- Gather feedback after you’ve deployed





Improving your thing

Listen hard

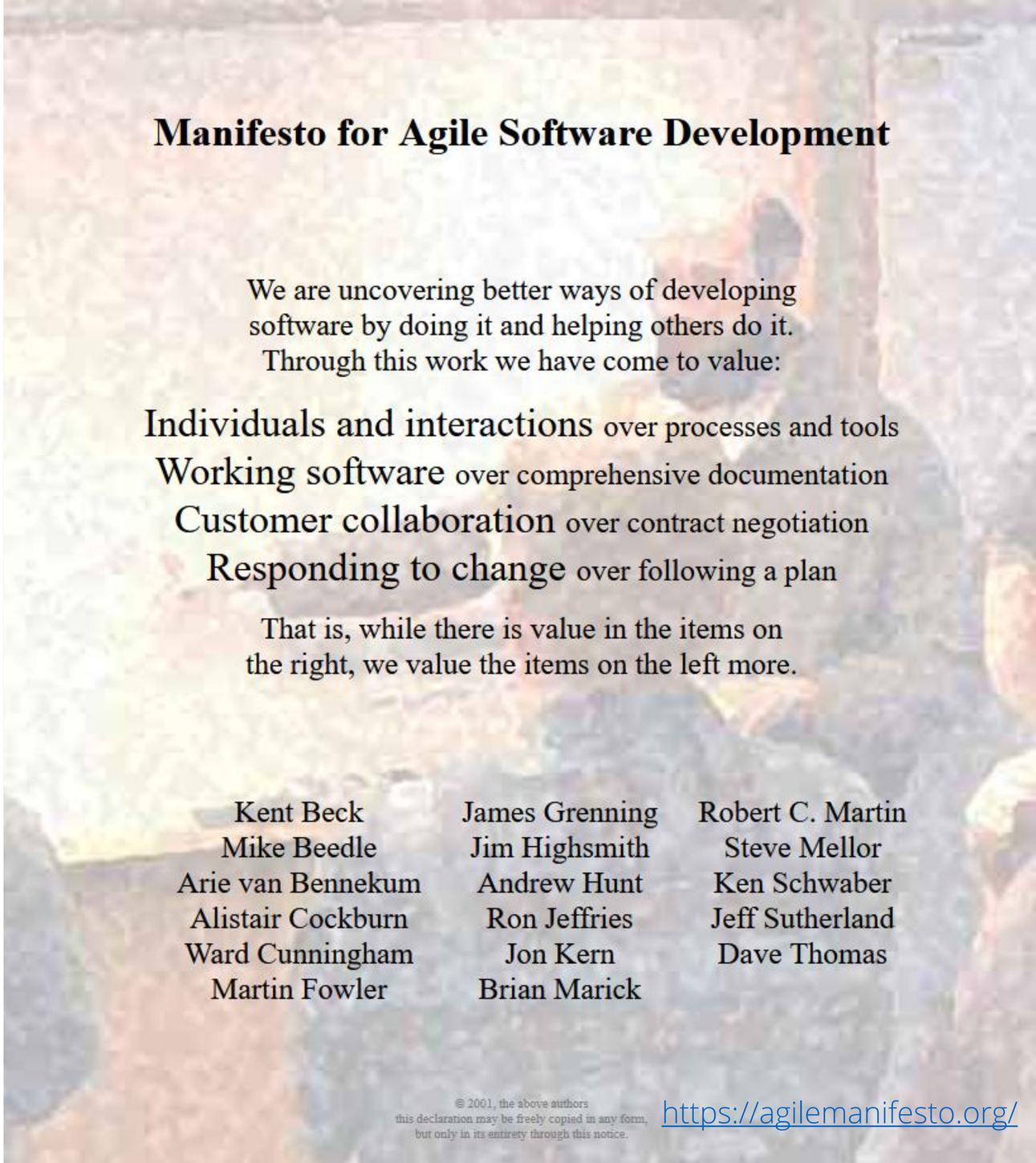
- YOU DO NOT KNOW WHAT THE USER WANTS
- The user also doesn't know what the user wants

Don't get attached to specific features

- If the users don't want/need it
- If it doesn't deliver the value you expected
- Pivot quickly
- Back yourself

Start from day one

- Gather feedback before you start building
- Gather feedback while you're building
- Gather feedback after you've deployed



So: Should You Build The Thing?

...

Yes!

You probably won’t become a gazillionaire

- Although, it would be nice bonus

You’ll learn a lot

- About technology
- About the domain
- About yourself

You’ll grow a lot

- In many different areas

It will be fun

- And fulfilling
- And you’ll make the world a better place



So: Should You Build The Thing?

...

No!

It will be stressful

- Talk to a professional
- Don’t catastrophise

The first time will be scary

- The next time will still be scary, but slightly less so

It is okay not to build a thing

- You do not have to build a thing
- You do not have to be an “entrepreneur”
- Do what makes you happy



So: Should You Build The Thing?

It’s up to you.

Yerren van Sint Annaland

Founder
Produce Intelligence LTD
yerren@produceintelligence.co.nz

AI Software Engineer
Stratos Technology Partners
y.annaland@stp.co.nz